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CHARM OFFENSIVE
Clockwise from left, Modi with the Trumps at Sabarmati Ashram in Ahmedabad, Feb. 2020, before the souring of Trump 2.0; with Xi Jinping during the Chinese president's 2014 visit; hosting Vladimir Putin on his recent trip



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India's Moment
Dec. 12, 2022

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"On December 1, when India formally assumed charge of the G20, its member nations represented 60 per cent of the world's population and, more importantly, accounted for 85 per cent of global GDP. Since its inception in 1999, the G20 has emerged as the world's most powerful international forum for major economic issues and, more recently, for geopolitical concerns as well. Coincidentally, India will also assume the presidency of the United Nations Security Council for a month in December.... It is truly India's moment on the world stage."

desh erupted in 2024 with Sheikh Hasina's ouster, and Nepal burned this year with Gen Z protests against the elite, India held fast to its 'Neighbourhood First' policy—committed to strengthening people-to-people, trade and infrastructure ties with its neighbours.

Simultaneously, it continued to 'Look East'—deepening engagement across the Indo-Pacific through forums such as ASEAN. These were also the years when India began to 'Think West', expanding its outreach to West Asian nations through successive visits. India also emerged as a prominent voice or the Global South, most notably during its G20 presidency in 2024.

But just when India seemed to have carved a distinct place in the world order—holding its own among the superpowers, dehyphenated from Pakistan and a central player in the post-COVID 'China Plus One' strategy—Donald Trump returned to the White House. His renewed MAGA mania upended the global order and triggered a bruising trade war in which India bore the unfair brunt of a 50 per cent duty on its goods as punishment for buying Russian oil. Why, Trump even reached out to Pakistan's all-powerful general, Asim Munir, soon after India's military response to a terror strike by Pakistani militants in Pahalgam.

Yet as President Putin remarked on his recent visit, "India is a global power in its own right; it cannot be arm-twisted." For the Modi government, capitulation is simply not an option. ■

